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COMMENTARY

Top Ten Global Risks for 2024

Persistent conflict in Africa, the Middle East, and Ukraine, the consequences of climate change, and emerging technologies may pose heightened risks this year

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Grand Strategy

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Introduction

This is the seventh edition of our annual “Top Ten Global Risks,” [an exercise](#) in foresight drawn from our forecasting experience at the U.S. intelligence community’s National Intelligence Council. In our [previous forecast](#), we focused on the proliferation of small wars, food insecurity, developing-country debt, and growing climate-change impacts — an ongoing *polycrisis*, entangled events and developments linked to and cascading off each other — is emblematic of our times: The post-World War II global system that the U.S.

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Africa's Second Lost Decade

Probability:



The confluence of numerous disruptive global trends unfortunately merges in Africa. With an intractable debt crisis, the drying up of capital flows, growing impacts of climate change, and major drought, conflict and political instability are now endemic across a large swathe of Africa — from the Sahel, including Mali, and Niger to Southern Sudan, Sudan and Ethiopia.

By 2050, a [quarter of the world's population will be African](#), with a projected one billion in their prime working-age years of 25-59, a “[doubling of its share of world population workforce from 12% to 23%](#),” according to the chief of the UN’s population estimates. Absent more economic growth and greater job opportunities, the risk of Africa’s demographic bounty becoming a liability for the region as well as the world will continue to grow.

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challenging, emblematic of [the gap](#) between industrialized and [developing nations](#) becoming more difficult to narrow. While the members of the global community need to view Africa as an essential part of their future and invest and trade with African countries more, these countries have some levers to attract more economic help. Diversifying trade with Asia would provide new opportunities that did not necessarily compete with current trade patterns focused on Europe and the Americas. But conflict, climate change, and a less friendly global environment steepen the curve for economic recovery and development.

Trump 2.0: Upending the United States’ “Internationalist” Role

Probability:



Former President Donald Trump has at least a 50-50 prospect of winning the 2024 election. His main theme would be revenge — and his reelection would most likely wreak havoc on U.S. democracy and further destabilize the world system. As [Trump has said](#) to

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Italy) show an emerging popular drift in the direction of Hungary's authoritarian regimes and changing the political landscape.

Should Trump come to power, the entire West might veer away from its longstanding internationalist path. He has hinted that he wants the U.S. to leave or reduce its role in NATO(e.g., suspend the U.S. commitment to Article 5 of the NATO Treaty) if demands for much greater European spending are not met and similarly try to pull U.S. troops out of South Korea and Japan if these countries do not agree to more burden sharing of the costs associated with stationing U.S. forces in Asia. More broadly, Trump has suggested imposing a 10% tariff on all imports; this step would foster a trade war and curb support for international institutions. Trump's agenda could be mitigated if Democrats win back the House and/or keep the Senate. Alternatively, as [unlikely as it seems](#), if former South Carolina Governor Nikki Haley or Florida Governor Ron DeSantis were the GOP winning candidate, there would be more continuity and less radical change.

Stalemate Without a Ukrainian Breakthrough Next Year.

Probability:

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a psychological blow to Putin. Should 2024 be another disappointing year for the Ukrainians, Western pressure on Kyiv for cease-fire talks will most likely increase. Biden would reap a political benefit in his upcoming campaign by bringing an end to the fighting. Outside of a humiliating military defeat, however, it is unclear whether Putin would actually want cease-fire talks. If, as is all but certain, Putin is reelected in 2024, that could embolden him to extend and/or intensify the fighting.

In any event, Putin probably wants to wait for the possibility of a Trump presidency, in which case he might come under strong U.S. pressure to stop the fighting but could expect more favorable treatment in a peace deal. In the interim, Putin's strategy might be centered on greatly intensifying drone and missile attacks on Ukrainian cities, infrastructure, and ports as well in an effort to destroy Ukraine as a functioning nation-state rather than taking more territory. It is unclear how the US/NATO would respond to such an approach.

The Ongoing Israel-Palestine Conflict

Probability:

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concessions to Palestinians will fail. The anger, rage, and grief on both sides likely foreshadow a region that will remain a tinderbox, with settler violence against Palestinians on the West Bank or more Hamas attacks in Gaza or elsewhere finally igniting full-scale Hizballah attacks in northern Israel or attacks by other Iranian proxies elsewhere, including against soft Western targets.

One wildcard that could heighten the risk to the region would be a possible succession crisis and political instability in Iran if the 84-year-old Iranian Supreme Leader passes in 2024.”

A Global Gap on Climate Change

Probability:



On the world’s current course, temperatures will rise to 2.9C above preindustrial levels, according to the latest UN *Emissions Gap Report*. Temperatures have already risen 1.1C,

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United Kingdom pledged about \$76 million; Japan \$10 million, and the EU (including Germany) offered to contribute about \$245 million. Washington was criticized for promising [only \\$17.5 million](#) by climate activists, but Republican legislators are likely to block any amount.

COP28 has nevertheless surprised many with the number of measures including a pledge to [phase out fossil fuels](#), private sector commitments to eliminate methane emissions by 2050 under the Global Methane Pledge (both non-binding), and a new climate [damage fund](#) to aid developing states adapt to climate change. [McKinsey](#) consulting firm estimates that “the world faces a \$41 trillion mitigation investment gap to 2030, with emerging markets facing a higher gap as a share of their GDP. In addition, an adaptation financing gap of \$600 billion is required annually to 2050, which is 10–18 times greater than current flows.” COP28 made some headway in marshaling the needed capital for mitigation and adaptation, but there is still a long way to go. The sense of inequity felt by developing countries — many more of which are impacted by climate change than richer countries — is unlikely to dissipate. Most developing country representatives did not leave COP28 feeling in any way assured that the West “has their back” on meeting the demands of climate change.

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rise to the level of alliances. The most ominous is what we are calling the *Eurasian Challenge*, a loose, transactional group encompassing two nuclear and veto-wielding UN Security Council members, Russia and China, along with one current and one soon-to-be nuclear power, North Korea and Iran. The alignment, held together by opposition to US power, does not yet equate to an alliance – but is nevertheless worrying.

Beijing has dropped the “no-limits” designation for its partnership with Moscow, but Russia and China are increasingly collaborating on a strategy to counter the U.S., North Korea and Iran, long pariahs, are using new transactional inter-action to align more with Sino-Russian interests. Iranian drones have proven to be important for Russia’s war against Ukraine, and North Korea is [providing more arms](#) after [Kim Jong Un’s visit to Russia](#). Moreover, Russian missile technology [aided North Korea’s first successful satellite launch](#) in November. Beijing seeks to build a Sino-centric alternative global order and benefits in multiple ways from a solid partnership with its Eurasian neighbors.

A [congressionally mandated commission](#) is already calling for an increase in U.S. nuclear arms to counter the Sino-Russian alignment. Ties among all four countries vary, but for Washington, which has underestimated the strength of the Russo-China bond and often fantasized about a renewed split between Moscow and Beijing, the expansion of that

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Taiwan (which will probably persist to the January elections), would most likely overreact to another DPP victory and raise its military, digital, and economic coercion to a new level. Since Taiwan began holding direct presidential elections in 1996, Beijing has pursued heavy-handed intimidation and coercive pressure during election seasons, though on [each occasion this tactic has backfired](#), with Beijing's favored candidates losing.

After tortured efforts, the opposition candidates failed to unite behind one ticket, making it a three-way race. Absent a unified opposition, the DPP will be the probable victor, per current polling. Opposition candidates favor renewed cross-Straits dialogue and would most likely pursue significant political, social, and economic interaction with Beijing.

Meanwhile, US-China tensions have eased slightly following the [November Biden-Xi Summit](#) designed to put a floor under the relationship through 2024. Nevertheless, if implementation of Chinese commitments on stopping fentanyl precursors, AI cooperation, and military-to-military talks falter, all bets are off. Beijing has not reduced its assertive maritime actions in the South China Sea nor near Taiwan. Biden reaffirmed the United States' "One-China" policy based on [three foundational communiques](#) and the 1979 [Taiwan Relations Act](#). Growing support for arming and defending Taiwan in

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Probability:



The memory of nuclear crises such as the 1962 Cuban Missile Crisis has faded. The post-Cold War framework for strategic stability has unraveled in direct proportion to heightened US-Russia tensions, and the Ukraine war has all but severed these ties, effectively [nullifying](#) the 1990 Conventional Forces in Europe and 1987 Intermediate-Range Nuclear Forces treaties.

Moreover, on the first anniversary of its Ukraine invasion, Moscow declared it was [suspending participation](#) in the New Start accord that limits the U.S. and Russia to 1,550 deployed nuclear warheads and expires in 2026. Putin signed a law [withdrawing Russia](#) from the Comprehensive Test Ban Treaty.

North Korea is building a formidable second-strike capability and new missile capacity with [Russia's help](#), and there are prospective chains of proliferation in the Greater Middle

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and satellite responses — are creating new vulnerabilities for nuclear powers, shrinking decision times, and stoking fears of first strikes – even as arms control efforts seem far off. Talks with China on committing to humans in control of nuclear weapons are a modestly encouraging step.

AI Possibilities

Probability:



The fear that AI and its physical expression — robots— could soon be smarter than humans has divided Silicon Valley, with the Godfather of AI, Geoffrey Hinton, and dozens of other [leading AI developers](#) warning of “the risk of extinction,” and [most dramatically at OpenAI](#), which created Chatbot GPT, now fully on the side of speeding up AI development and promoting the opportunities.

[Large language models \(LLMs\)](#) of generative AI are exponentially improving a wide range of capabilities as Chat GPT4, Google, Meta, Microsoft, dozens of startups, and China race



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accountability norms are still elusive. But regulation alone would not contain risks

Mustafa Suleyman, an AI pioneer and the founder of Deep Mind, fears, containing AI may be all but impossible. Suleyman argues in a new book, *The Coming Wave*, that regulation must be paired with adequate systematic research on AI safety, of which there is relatively little: We need to know why and how mistakes are made by AI, whether governments can stress-test AI systems and access and correct flawed systems, and whether there is a solely human-controlled off-switch. We agree.

Certainty or Moral Absolutism: Undermining Global Cooperation

Probability:



All the risks discussed above are, to use former Defense Secretary Donald Rumsfeld’s term, “known unknowns: discernable events or trends whose trajectories we can assess.” But one intangible driver of many of these trends has not been adequately considered: certainty or moral absolutism.

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managing history,” explaining that “modern man lacks the humility to accept the fact that the whole drama of history is enacted in a frame of meaning too large for human comprehension or management.” As the late Henry Kissinger [admonished](#), “History presents unambiguous alternatives only in the rarest of circumstances.”

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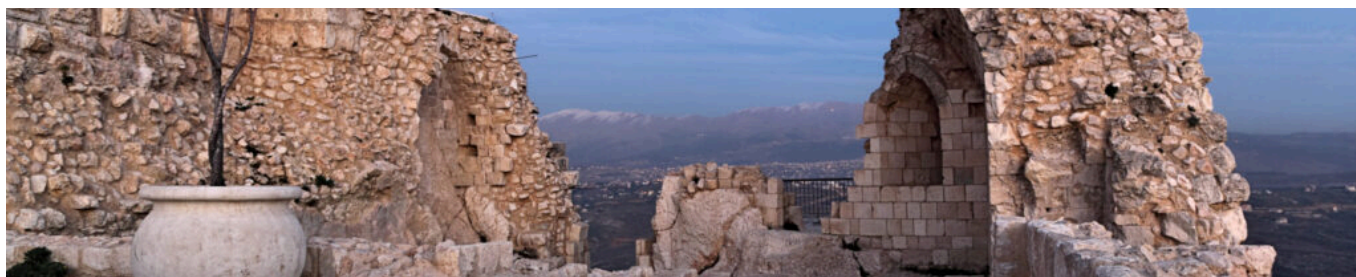
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